them’. Xuanzang saw a copper statue of Shiva ‘somewhat less than 100 feet high’ which ‘is grave and majestic, and appears as though really living’.[10]

In the early eleventh century, Alberuni visited India during the years it was repeatedly raided by Mahmud of Ghazni. In his account, Alberuni calls Varanasi a leading centre of the ‘Hindu sciences’ and a place ‘venerated for reasons connected with their law and religion’, though he didn’t visit the city. Much as ‘the dwellers of the Ka’ba stay for ever in Mecca,’ he writes, Hindu ascetics go to Varanasi ‘to live there to the end of their lives, that their reward after death should be the better for it’. ‘They say that a murderer is held responsible for his crime and punished . . . except in case he enters the city of Benares, where he obtains pardon’—a karmic pardon, Alberuni likely means—by the automatic attainment of moksha for dying in this hallowed city.

Around 1700 years after the kingdom of Kashi had fallen, Varanasi again became a capital city in 1090 CE. For a century hence, under the Gahadavala Dynasty, it thrived as a capital located on the Rajghat Plateau in northern Varanasi. The kings of the Gahadavala Dynasty patronized Varanasi and Kannauj as centres of Hindu pilgrimage, funded works of religious literature and culture and made land endowments to temples and Brahmins, such as to the Kashi Vishwanath Temple and King Chandradeva’s donation of thirty-two villages to five hundred Brahmins in 1100 CE.[11] At the end of the twelfth century, a weak Gahadavala dynast was defeated by the armies of Sultan Muhammad of Ghori, whose recent ancestors in Afghanistan had left Buddhism to embrace Islam. From 1192–94 CE, his Turkic commander, Qutb-ud-din Aibak—commanding a disciplined cavalry-led army of mercenaries often paid in war booty— defeated Prithviraj Chauhan and killed Jayachandra, the last Gahadavala king, plundered his capital in Varanasi and desecrated many temples. In 1206, Aibak inaugurated a new political dynasty in the north: the Delhi Sultanate.